

User Research Findings: Small-Business Brain

Overview

This document compiles primary research gathered for the Small-Business Brain project, a WhatsApp-first AI agent for Pakistani SMEs. Research includes a 7-response survey of small business owners and six follow-up interviews conducted directly over WhatsApp, Instagram, or by phone with small business owners across food, retail, and home-based businesses.

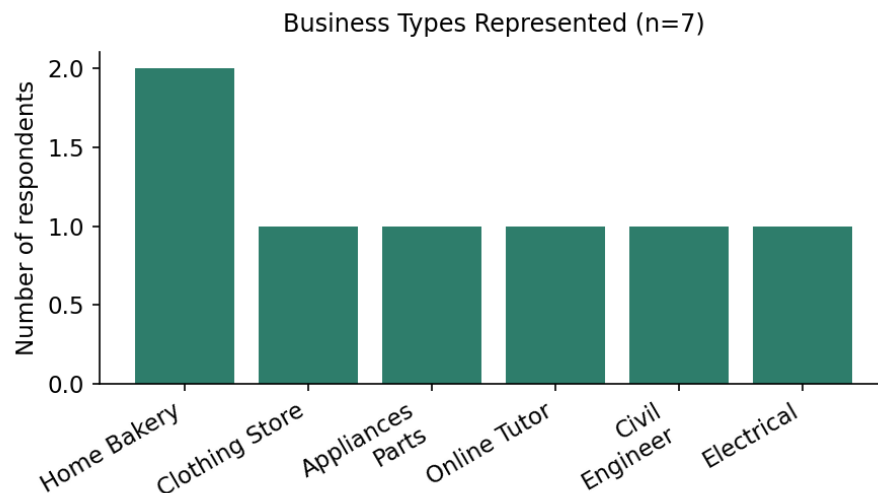
Methodology

- Survey distributed to small business owners across multiple sectors (7 responses collected)
- Six semi-structured follow-up interviews and cold outreach conversations conducted over WhatsApp, Instagram, and phone calls, covering a hostel-focused home food business, a bakery, a cafe, two home-based food businesses, and one home-based non-food business (crochet), to go deeper on daily workflow and pain points

Part 1: Survey Findings

Respondent profile

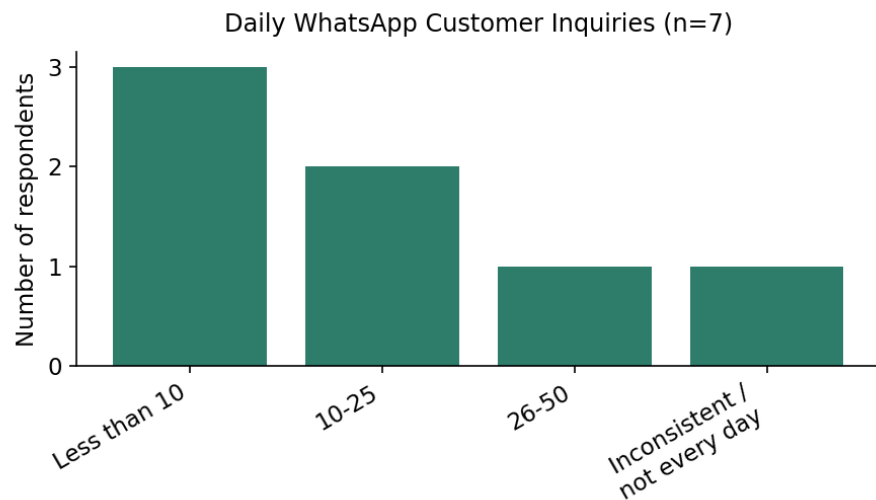
- Business types represented: Home Bakery (2), Clothing Store (1), Appliances Parts (1), Online Tutor (1), Civil Engineer (1), Electrical (1)
- Business age: 1-3 years (3), less than 6 months (2), 6 months-1 year (1), 5 years (1)



Note: one respondent works in construction/civil engineering and flagged that the survey questions were framed around retail-style businesses and did not map cleanly onto their field. Worth accounting for in future survey design.

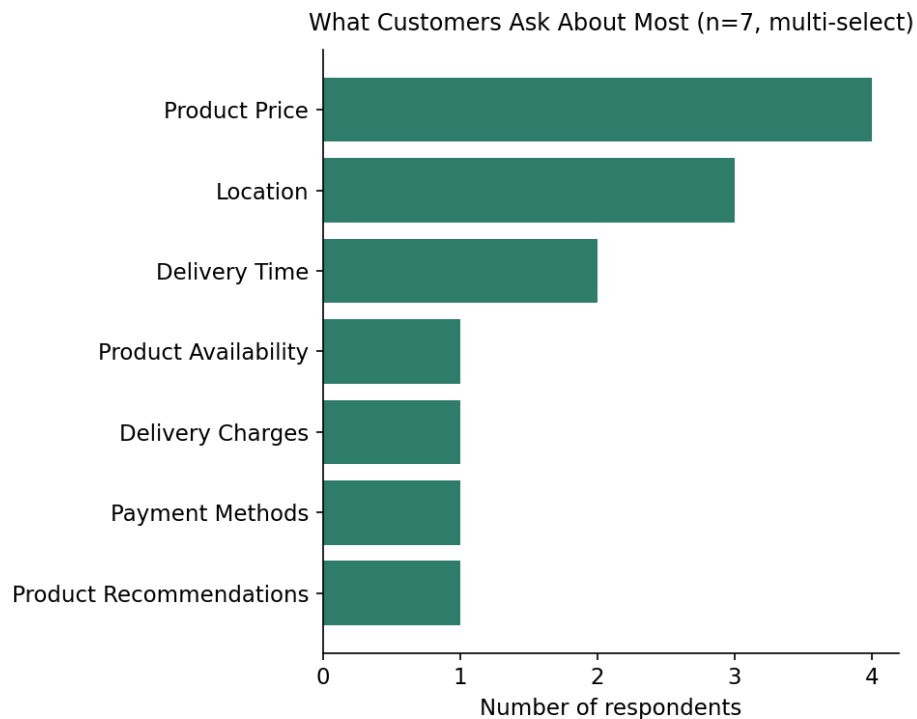
Communication volume and channels

- Daily WhatsApp inquiries: less than 10 (3), 10-25 (2), 26-50 (1), inconsistent/not everyone (1)
- 6 of 7 respondents already use WhatsApp Business
- Primary channel for managing inquiries: WhatsApp (6), phone calls (1), Instagram (2), with some overlap across channels
- Time spent replying to customer messages daily: less than 30 minutes (4), 30-60 minutes (1), 1-2 hours (2)



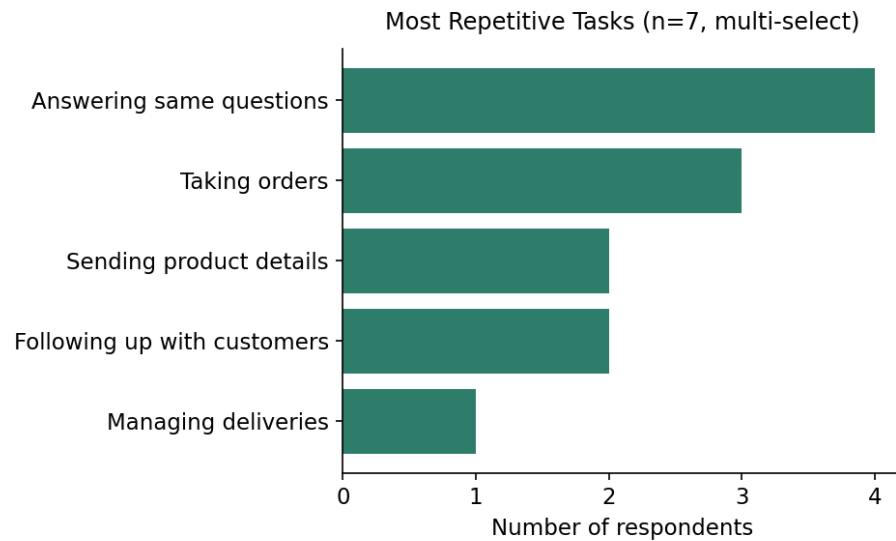
What customers ask about most

- Product price (4)
- Location (3)
- Delivery time (2)
- Product availability, delivery charges, payment methods, product recommendations (1 each)

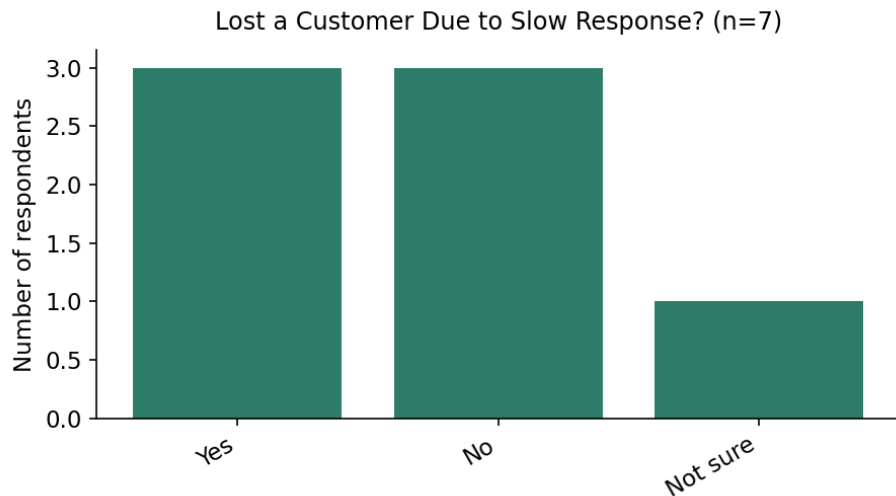


Pain points

- Most repetitive tasks: answering the same questions repeatedly (4), taking orders (3), sending product details (2), following up with customers (2)



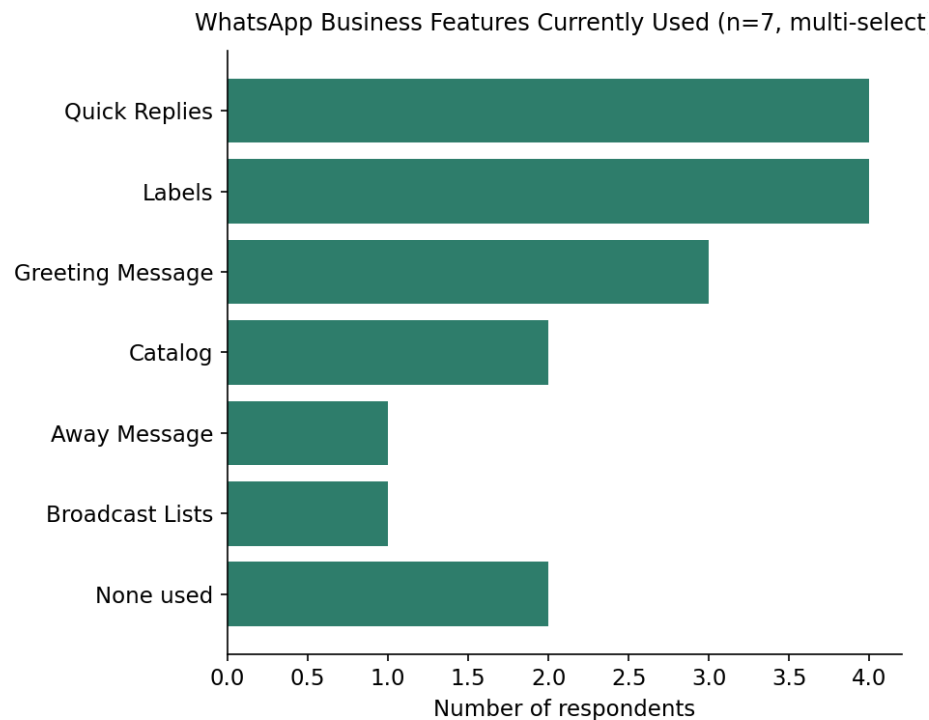
- 3 of 7 respondents have lost a customer due to slow response time, 3 said no, 1 was unsure



- Biggest cited challenges: pricing confusion (especially for customized products), lack of timely response, and handling multiple customers at once when most incoming questions are repeats of each other
- When asked what single task they would automate: answering repetitive questions and automating price/product detail responses came up most often

Existing tool usage

- WhatsApp Business features currently in use: Quick Replies (4), Labels (4), Catalog (2), Greeting Message (3), Away Message (1), Broadcast Lists (1)
- 2 of 7 respondents use no special features at all despite having WhatsApp Business



- Desired but missing features: automated replies, and a way to link an external system directly into WhatsApp
- 5 of 7 respondents agreed to a follow-up interview, indicating strong willingness to engage further

Part 2: User Interviews

Interview 1: Home Food Business, Hostel-Focused (Noor, WhatsApp interview)

Noor runs a home-based food business, primarily selling homemade meals to people who cannot cook for themselves, mainly hostel students from a nearby university. She also sells frozen food items during Ramadan and for parties and family gatherings (dawats).

Business background

- Running the business for 1.5 years, sourced almost entirely through WhatsApp with no separate social media presence
- Client acquisition was easy early on due to personal networks (was an HRM student at the time), so growth relied on word of mouth rather than paid or organic marketing
- Currently considering winding the business down, which surfaced naturally while discussing workload rather than being stated as a direct reason

Daily workflow

- Receives 25-30 messages per day, almost every day
- Menu is decided in advance on a weekly basis and posted daily to her WhatsApp status
- Orders are only accepted before 10am each day
- She caps orders based on how much she can realistically prepare (for example, capping biryani orders at 15 servings) and does not accept beyond that limit
- Once an item's order cap is reached, she posts an update to her status marking it as closed

Core pain point

The status update workaround does not fully solve the repetition problem, because not everyone views her WhatsApp status. Customers who miss the status still message her individually to ask whether today's menu item is available, whether it is sold out, or when it will be ready, even after she has already communicated that information elsewhere.

Most repeated customer questions

- What is today's menu
- What is the half-serving price and portion size
- What time will the food be ready
- Can I place a customized order (only accepted 3 days in advance)
- Can I order frozen items for a dawwat (only accepted 3 days in advance)
- Is this item still available / has it sold out

What she wants automated

When asked directly what she would want WhatsApp (or an assistant acting on her behalf) to handle while she is away, she named two things specifically:

- Confirming the daily menu and order details to customers automatically
- Automatically notifying customers when an item's maximum order count is reached, so they find out it's sold out without needing to ask her directly

Interview 2: Lahore Sweets and Bakers, Behlolpur (cold outreach)

A local bakery. Workers there struggle to read text messages and prefer voice notes and calls instead. However, female customers are hesitant to call or send voice notes to male staff and prefer texting instead, creating a mismatch between how staff want to communicate and how a portion of customers are comfortable communicating. Most queries hit during evening peak hours and are mainly customers checking whether items are available. When the business gets too overwhelmed to take more orders, staff simply turn off WhatsApp entirely rather than manage the incoming volume.

Interview 3: Duke's Cafe (cold call)

Rush hour runs from 6pm to midnight, during which the cafe is hit with 5-6 calls and over 10 chats arriving at the same time, which they described as very difficult to manage. Even though prices are already listed in their WhatsApp product catalog, customers still message asking for the price every time. Because chat volume is so high, active orders get pushed down in the inbox and are sometimes missed or delayed simply because staff forget about them.

Interview 4: Amazing Bites, home food business (Shagufta)

Shagufta runs a home food business and takes orders through regular WhatsApp, with most customers coming through word of mouth and referrals. Her customers are mostly office workers, students, and bachelors. She follows a fixed daily menu that regular customers are already familiar with, while other customers place custom orders and specify a preferred delivery time. She tries to take orders a day in advance, especially for breakfast and dinner, though she occasionally accepts urgent orders. A recurring challenge is customers asking the same questions repeatedly and trying to negotiate prices even after she has already shared them. Since everything is managed manually on WhatsApp, she said it would help if customers placed orders in advance and on time, so she can plan and prepare more efficiently.

Interview 5: Home-based crochet business (Zoha)

Zoha runs a small home-based crochet business, outside the food/bakery focus of the rest of this research but included since her experience surfaced relevant patterns. She manages everything through Instagram rather than WhatsApp, and one of her biggest issues is that DMs sometimes land in Instagram's separate message requests

folder, causing her to miss potential customers or reply too late. Customers often stop replying partway through a conversation or take a long time to send the details needed to place an order. Advance payment is another friction point, since some customers are hesitant to pay online even though it's necessary to avoid fake or unclaimed orders. She and her sister currently manage everything manually, and she specifically flagged how much time goes into answering the same questions and sending product photos repeatedly, even though the information is already posted on their Instagram page.

Interview 6: Home-based brownie business, Lahore (Mahnoor)

Mahnoor runs a home-based brownie business and is currently trying to expand it. She takes orders through both WhatsApp and Instagram, collects advance payments, and uses Yango or InDrive for delivery instead of Foodpanda because of high commission costs. Most orders are placed a day in advance, but she occasionally receives urgent same-day requests that are difficult to manage. Her biggest pain point is that if she's busy baking, has internet issues, or is away from her phone for 3-4 hours, customers don't get timely replies and often lose interest. She also has to manually track incoming orders, payment confirmations, delivery details, and finances, which becomes overwhelming. She said it would help to have something that could receive orders, automatically acknowledge and confirm them, and keep everything organized while she's offline or occupied, so she doesn't lose potential customers to delayed responses.

Key Insights for Small-Business Brain

- Repetitive question-answering is the single most consistent pain point across every source. It's the top-cited repetitive task in the survey, and it shows up independently in the interviews with the hostel-focused food business, Amazing Bites, the crochet business, and Duke's Cafe, even businesses with prices already listed in a catalog (Duke's Cafe) still get asked for pricing on nearly every order.
- Overload doesn't just slow businesses down, it makes them disengage entirely. The clearest example is Lahore Sweets and Bakers turning off WhatsApp completely when order volume gets to be too much, and Duke's Cafe losing or delaying orders because active chats get buried under new messages during rush hour. This is a step beyond slow replies, it's businesses temporarily going dark or actively dropping orders under load.
- Communication preference is not one-size-fits-all, and gender dynamics matter. Lahore Sweets and Bakers staff prefer voice notes and calls, but female customers are hesitant to send voice notes or call male staff and prefer texting. Any automation that assumes one communication mode (e.g. voice-first) risks excluding a real segment of customers.
- Status updates and posted information are an underused workaround with a real gap. The hostel-focused interviewee already built her own manual system (weekly menu, status posts, order caps) to reduce repetition, and it still fails because visibility is inconsistent, the same pattern shows up with Duke's Cafe (catalog prices ignored) and the crochet business (Instagram bio information ignored). This points to a concrete feature opportunity: an agent that proactively answers from posted information rather than relying on customers to have seen it.
- Order-cap and inventory tracking is a real, recurring manual workflow, not a hypothetical one. The hostel-focused interviewee already thinks in terms of hard caps per item per day, and Mahnoor separately described manually tracking orders, payments, delivery details, and finances all at once. An agent that can track a running order count or order status against a preset limit would replace a manual step several of these businesses already perform daily.
- Being away from the phone is a direct, named cause of lost customers. Mahnoor specifically described losing customer interest when she can't reply for 3-4 hours due to baking, poor internet, or being away from her phone, this is a distinct and more concrete version of the lost a customer due to slow response pattern that 3 of 7 survey respondents also reported.
- Willingness to delegate is high but scoped, and payment automation is a trust issue, not just a convenience one. Businesses want automation for menu confirmation, availability updates, and order acknowledgment, not full autonomous transaction handling. The crochet business specifically flagged customer hesitancy around advance online payments, suggesting payment collection needs careful, trust-building design rather than being treated as a simple automation step.

- Customized, negotiated, and advance orders need separate handling from standard inquiries. Amazing Bites deals with repeated price negotiation even after prices are shared, and multiple businesses (the hostel-focused interviewee, Amazing Bites, Mahnoor) prefer or require advance ordering with same-day requests treated as an exception. Any automation should clearly separate what it can resolve on its own from what needs a human's judgment call.
- The problem isn't unique to WhatsApp as a channel. The crochet business showed the same core pattern (repetitive questions, missed messages, delayed replies) happening on Instagram DMs instead, including a platform-specific failure mode (DMs landing in message requests). This suggests the underlying problem is about business owners being single points of failure for customer communication generally, not a WhatsApp-specific quirk, worth keeping in mind for how broadly to scope the product later on.